

Pennsylvania Right-to-Know (RTK) Request: Operational Strategy & Automation Guide

1. Dual-Agency Submission Strategy

Because Pennsylvania decouples public health benefit administration from its commercial exchange, determine whether your request requires dual submission:

- **PA Department of Human Services (DHS)**
 - **Scope:** Medical Assistance (Medicaid), CHIP enrollment, fee-for-service data, and Managed Care Organization (MCO) capitation contracts.
 - **Submission Channel:** [Official PA DHS RTK Portal](#) or direct email to the designated DHS Agency Open-Records Officer (AORO).
- **Pennie (PA Health Insurance Exchange Authority)**
 - **Scope:** Commercial marketplace operations, ACA plan enrollment, individual market outreach, and exchange-level communications.
 - **Submission Channel:** Direct email/mail to Pennie's designated Open-Records Officer.

Recommendation: If your query bridges Medicaid unwinding, transitions to exchange plans, or joint communications, submit parallel RTK requests to both entities simultaneously.

2. Search Parameter Optimization & Denials Prevention

Under **65 P.S. § 67.503**, agencies frequently issue 30-day extensions or initial denials citing an *insufficiently specific request* (**Section 703**). Apply the following refinements:

Key Custodians (Scope Restriction)

- **Office of Income Maintenance (OIM)**
- **Office of Medical Assistance Programs (OMAP)**
- **Office of Communications**

Recommended Search Term Variations (Boolean & Exact Match)

To capture internal agency dialogue and draft guidance, include variations such as:

- "10% loss stop" | "10 percent loss stop" | "loss-stop"
- "communication pause" | "communications freeze" | "outreach moratorium"
- "MLR threshold" | "capitation adjustment"

3. Submission Protocol & Statutory Timeline

Under **Section 901**, the agency must respond within **5 business days** of receiving the request.

Timeline Milestone	Event / Action Required	Statutory Reference
Day 0	Request submitted. Retain automated portal receipt or sent-email headers.	—
Day 5	Mandatory Agency Response Due: Fulfillment, Denial, or Section 902 Notice.	65 P.S. § 67.901
Day 5 + 30 Days	Maximum extension period if Section 902 extension invoked.	65 P.S. § 67.902

4. Terminal Automation Workflows

File Path Verification

The template is located at:

```
/home/droid/whysoquit/rtk_request.txt
```

To verify file existence and preview content:

```
# Verify file listing
```

```
ls -l ~/whysoquit/rtk_request.txt
```

```
# Search entire home directory if path moves
```

```
find ~ -type f -name 'rtk_request.txt' 2>/dev/null
```

```
# Preview header and footer of document
```

```
sed -n '1,35p' ~/whysoquit/rtk_request.txt
```

```
tail -35 ~/whysoquit/rtk_request.txt
```

```
# Locate remaining unpopulated placeholder brackets
```

```
grep -nE '\[^\]]+\]' ~/whysoquit/rtk_request.txt
```

Direct String Replacement & Final Compilation

Run the following script block to populate applicant metadata and output rtk_request_final.txt:

```
# Set environment variables
```

```
NAME="Anthony Dee"
```

```
ADDR="Your Street Address"
```

```
CITY_ZIP="Allentown, PA 18101"
```

```
EMAIL="your.email@domain.com"
```

```
PHONE="555-555-5555"
```

```
# Run batch replacements using sed
```

```
sed -e "s/[Your full name\]/$NAME/g" \
```

```
-e "s/[Your mailing address\]/$ADDR/g" \
```

```
-e "s/[City, State ZIP\]/$CITY_ZIP/g" \
```

```
-e "s/[Your email address\]/$EMAIL/g" \
```

```
-e "s/[Your telephone number, optional\]/$PHONE/g" \  
-e "s/[START DATE\] through \[END DATE\]/January 01, 2024 through September 07,  
2026/g" \  
~/whysoquit/rtk_request.txt > ~/whysoquit/rtk_request_final.txt
```

Post-Processing Verification

After running the script, confirm that no unpopulated brackets remain:

```
grep -nE "[[^\]]+\]" ~/whysoquit/rtk_request_final.txt
```

If the command returns no output, the request file is ready for submission.